

Samsung Galaxy A16 5G

Strictly mediocre

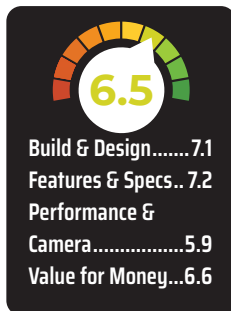
The Samsung Galaxy A16 5G recently debuted in India, priced at ₹18,999. Samsung has long catered to budget-conscious buyers with its Galaxy A series, and the Galaxy A16 5G is no exception. Positioned as an affordable entry into the 5G world, this phone emphasises practicality over innovation. While it doesn't have cutting-edge performance, it promises to offer a dependable experience for everyday users. With modest upgrades over its predecessor and a focus on essentials like a long-lasting battery and decent display, the Galaxy A16 5G competes in the crowded mid-range segment. But does it strike the right balance of features and value? Additionally, how does it fare compared to the likes of the popular Motorola G85 and OnePlus Nord CE4 Lite? Let's find out.

BUILD AND DESIGN

The Galaxy A16 5G is quintessentially Samsung, flaunting a modern, minimalist design with gentle curves and a compact frame. Its glossy plastic back is a magnet for fingerprints, but it feels surprisingly robust in hand, lacking any hollowness or flex. The plastic frame and back, while less premium than metal or glass, ensure a lightweight build and signal-friendly design. The back also houses the typical vertical array of triple cameras you get to see across Samsung's diverse portfolio of phones.

At just 7.9 mm thick, the A16 5G feels comfortable to hold, with subtle slopes along the right edge of the phone, enhancing the grip. Available in three colour options – Gold, Blue Black, and Light Green – the phone caters to diverse tastes. Our review unit in Light Green offers an under-

₹18,999



stated elegance, though the glossy finish might not appeal to everyone.

One standout feature is its IP54 rating, which provides basic protection against dust and water splashes. While it won't survive a swim, the device can handle occasional spills.

The front is made of an unspecified glass, and it lacks a factory-fitted screen protector, so investing in one is advisable. The bezels are thinner than its predecessor, but the teardrop notch remains a relic in a world moving towards punch-hole cameras.

The phone, given its price, skips on an in-display fingerprint scanner, instead going for a simple capacitive one housed on the power button. I have no complaints here, as it's exceedingly accurate and easy to use. One major gripe I have is the lack of stereo speakers; instead, you get a single loudspeaker on the A16, which is a huge disadvantage as competing Motorola and OnePlus phones house excellent dual stereo speakers.

DISPLAY

Samsung is known for its superior display technology, however, the Galaxy A16 5G disappoints within its price bracket. While the 6.7-inch Super AMOLED panel delivers vibrant colours and deep blacks, its 90 Hz display feels dated compared to similarly-priced 120 Hz budget phones. Discerning users will be able to feel the drop in smoothness compared to 120 Hz displays.

Brightness levels are decent, with the screen performing well indoors and under shade. However, direct sunlight can pose challenges, where competitors like the Redmi Note 13 Pro, Motorola G85, and OnePlus Nord CE4 Lite fare better. The lack of HDR support also limits its appeal for streaming enthusiasts, however, you do get Widevine L1 support for HD viewing.

The Always-On Display feature, inherited from pricier Samsung models, is a pleasant surprise though. It adds convenience allowing users to quickly glance at notifications without unlocking their device. However, the lack of Corning Gorilla Glass or similar protection raises durability concerns.

All in all, I'd consider the Samsung Galaxy A16 to be one of the weaker displays in the budget smartphone market given its missing key features like 120 Hz refresh rate and high brightness levels. The phone also lacks adaptive refresh rate switching, which is present on several competitors.

PERFORMANCE AND SOFTWARE

Under the hood, the Galaxy A16 5G comes in two chipset variants: Samsung's Exynos 1330 for the global market and MediaTek's Dimensity 6300 in select regions. In India, you get the variant with the Dimensity 6300 chipset. It is built on a 6 nm process, emphasising power efficiency over raw performance. The phone is equipped with up to 8 GB RAM and up to 256 GB internal storage, expandable via microSD.

In day-to-day tasks like browsing, social media, and light gaming, the